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Expanding Campus Access to Religious Life at WashU

During my grandfather's final months battling cancer, my parents rarely left the hospital. Every night, after I called them, my sister looked to me for the dreaded head-shake: it was another overnight stay.

Yet my siblings and I were collectively cared for. Families created schedules, taking turns to deliver home-cooked meals, drive my siblings and me to activities, and offering countless prayers behind the scenes. These saints have shaped me far beyond my faith, molding my core values: of care, a strong community and support system, and openness. Younger ones in church hold a special place in my heart. Their faces light up when they see me, handing me mismatched beaded bracelets and letters with my name in misshapen handwriting. I now dedicate my time serving them, leading meetings with singing, lessons, and crafts, changing diapers, and teaching little hands motions to children's hymns—simply giving back the love I received growing up. The outpouring goes both ways, both with others serving me and how much fulfillment I find as I then serve others. My church is a multiethnic network that holds a seemingly ceaseless love for others, regardless of whether they're strangers or speak the same language. From Chicago to Anaheim to Taiwan, I'm welcomed like family.

At Washington University in St. Louis, students seem to have everything. At their fingertips, students have access to world-class academics and almost every campus resource imaginable. Yet for some communities, notably smaller religious groups, access remains constrained. For the local churches in the Lord's Recovery, access is constrained not by interest but by distance. The Church in St. Louis, located roughly thirty minutes by car from campus (17 miles) in Bridgeton, MO, currently serves only a handful of WashU students.

Going to church requires time and finding transportation on early Sunday mornings for WashU students, a majority of whom do not have cars, including myself. Students would then have to rely on Uber, Lyft, or public transport. Realistically, many students cannot commit to this sustained effort. As a result, only about five students attend regularly.

This gap reflects a structural barrier, not a lack of need. The church should expand its on-campus presence through a registered student organization and structured programming. By lowering access barriers, becoming a student organization, and leveraging existing campus infrastructure, this initiative would expand participation, allowing the students to further be fulfilled while bringing the Church in St. Louis to more people. This further aligns with the university's broader mission of fostering inclusive communities and making resources continuously more accessible.

The first, most immediate barrier is physical accessibility. A thirty-minute commute may seem trivial in theory, but in practice, it's too far for most college students. Without cars, students rely on walking or campus transportation, neither of which supports off-campus travel, especially every weekend. Proximity strongly predicts participation. The easier something is to attend, the more likely students are to show up. This principle is visible across campus, otherwise it'll require additional effort. This has been the phenomenon happening so far, pushing the majority of students (15 out of 20, so 75%) who are in the Church in St. Louis from attending the Sunday morning meetings regularly.

Expanding on campus is not only necessary but also feasible, as seen with other religious campus organizations. We can see this particularly with the comparison to other religious organizations, such as Chabad, which maintains a house near campus. Because it is easily accessible (being within walking distance) and consistently active, Chabad events often reach full capacity, with my friends noting that they need to fill out in-advance sign-ups. Chabad is a perfect example of a successful religious organization that takes full advantage of its on-campus presence. Accessibility drives engagement. When participation requires minimal effort, students attend.

Because of the 30-minute commute, the current participation underestimates the true demand; the true number of students who would want to participate is higher. While only five students regularly attend

services, approximately twenty students have expressed interest but do not consistently participate due to the distance. Behavioral economics suggests that even small reductions in friction, including reducing travel time, can significantly increase participation. Economist Richard Thaler and legal scholar Cass Sunstein, in their work on behavioral economics, demonstrate that even small barriers, precisely like added time or effort, significantly reduce engagement in activities (Thaler and Sunstein).¹ When participation becomes easier, behavior changes. Studies on “default effects” and “friction costs” show that participation rates can increase dramatically when effort is reduced, even without changing underlying interest (Madrian and Shea).² Following Madrian and Shea, this exemplifies suppressed demand. When barriers are high, interest does not translate into action. Removing those barriers will reveal the true level of engagement.

Beyond logistics, the lack of accessible religious spaces has broader implications for student well-being. Universities increasingly emphasize mental health, belonging, and identity development as central to the student experience, especially at WashU. Religious communities, like the Church in St. Louis, often provide these benefits. In my personal experience, the Church in St. Louis has brought me moral guidance, a sense of stability, and a community of people I can rely on. When access is limited, students, not only just the ones currently involved right now, but all of the potential students who would hear about the on-campus events and give it a try, lose an important avenue for connection. Research by psychologist Geoffrey Cohen at Stanford University shows that a strong sense of belonging improves academic performance and mental health (Cohen et al.).³ Students who feel connected to a community are more likely to thrive. The importance of finding a place for students to belong is crucial and beneficial for multiple facets of students’ lives.

¹ Thaler, Richard H., and Cass R. Sunstein. *Nudge: Improving Decisions About Health, Wealth, and Happiness*. Yale University Press, 2008.

² Madrian, Brigitte C., and Dennis F. Shea. “The Power of Suggestion: Inertia in 401(k) Participation and Savings Behavior.” *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, vol. 116, no. 4, 2001, pp. 1149–1187.

³ Cohen, Geoffrey L., et al. “Recursive Processes in Self-Affirmation: Intervening to Close the Minority Achievement Gap.” *Science*, vol. 324, no. 5925, 2009, pp. 400–403.

WashU itself emphasizes this value. The university states that it aims to create an environment where “every student feels a sense of belonging and support.”⁴ Religious organizations are one of the many ways students find that belonging.⁵

Expanding on-campus religious engagement is therefore not only a matter of convenience but also one of well-being and striving to meet WashU’s goal of making every student feel at home and have access to all the resources they would want.

Addressing this issue requires a clear, practical plan, requiring coordinated action across multiple levels. The first phase should focus on establishing a student-led organization. According to WashU’s Campus Life requirements, forming a new student group requires at least ten active members, a formal constitution, and a faculty or staff advisor. The existing network of interested students provides a foundation for recruitment, with the existing students advocating for this club. Vertically, the process begins with church leadership, who must approve and support the initiative. Horizontally, students play a critical role in building and sustaining the community. Student leaders then organize and execute the plan, working with WashU’s Campus Life office to secure official recognition. The Student Union provides funding, while the Office for Religious, Spiritual & Ethical Life (ORSEL) offers institutional support and integration into the university’s religious life ecosystem. A faculty advisor provides guidance and credibility, while partnerships with other organizations expand reach and visibility. A faculty advisor can be secured through outreach to professors or staff affiliated with religious or ethical life. Together, these stakeholders form a network of support that enables the initiative to succeed. Once registered, the organization can begin pilot planning the events. Maximizing events will push for the highest engagement. Additionally, collaboration with the Office for Religious, Spiritual & Ethical Life can provide guidance and access to broader networks, assuring that we reach more potential students. Easily, the student organization can plan to have weekly meetings with food, singing hymns, and readings (both

⁴ Washington University in St. Louis. “Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion.” Washington University in St. Louis, <https://diversity.wustl.edu/>. Accessed 22 Mar. 2026.

⁵ Washington University in St. Louis. “Office for Religious, Spiritual & Ethical Life.” *Washington University in St. Louis*, <https://orsel.wustl.edu/>. Accessed 22 Mar. 2026.

the Bible and the Life Studies of the Living Stream Ministry). These meetings will allow for immediate value for participants and demonstrate the feasibility of the on-campus organization to both the university and the church. As the group continues to grow, we will then apply for funding through the Student Union, which allocates resources to recognized student organizations.

Looking further into the future, church leadership can also contribute by providing materials, like free Bibles, lesson books, hymnals, bookmarks, etc., or even inviting guest speakers, like Brother Ed Marks or Brother Ron Kangas on to campus. Even more than that, if demand continues to grow, the church may explore establishing a more permanent presence near campus, potentially investing in a small center or shared space, like Chabad. While this is a longer-term goal, it becomes feasible only after initial success demonstrates sustained interest.

Critics may argue that such an initiative is unnecessary. With only five active participants, is there even a need? Allocating all of this time and resources potentially isn't necessary simply because it does not serve enough people; there's no demand, no need. However, this overlooks the central issue: participation is constrained by access. Knowing 20 students are a part of the Church in St. Louis while my own experience consistently shows around 5 of us actively making the trip over, it's clear the current numbers do not reflect true demand. When barriers are removed, participation increases. The number of potential students, not just the ones that are a part of the church already, but potential newcomers, the students who would engage if given the opportunity, brings back this need.

Practical obstacles remain. Time and funding are legitimate concerns. However, the proposed approach minimizes both. By starting with a student-led organization, the initiative requires minimal financial investment, relying first on the willingness and motivation of the students involved in the church already. Campus spaces are already available, and initial programming can be low-cost. Initial programming costs would include snacks/food, pamphlets and excerpts, and potentially other smaller goodies. As these events continue, the potential newcomers and currently uninvolved students will not only get closer to their faith, but also meet others who will become their community to depend on (as it has for me), ultimately bringing fulfillment. Because the Church in St. Louis, as well as the larger,

national network of the Local Churches, actively go out to preach, there are already lots of preaching materials printed and available. In a conversation with one of the supervisors at our church, Hannah Birchman, those resources can and should be used as a natural first step. Funding can be pursued gradually as the organization grows.⁶ After the initial investments and using the materials the church already has access to, additional funding from the Student Union will need to be acquired. Beyond simply time and funding, another obstacle that stands is institutional procedure. Without official recognition, the group cannot reserve rooms or host events. However, WashU makes the registration process for a student organization very straightforward, outlining all of the steps in order needed. WashU provides a clear pathway for forming student organizations, which are a key way students can find a community they belong to and can rely on, following WashU's goal of making all students feel accepted. As long as the creation of the on-campus organization follows the procedure above, there will be confirmed access to resources and legitimacy.

Finally, sustaining engagement presents a longer-term challenge. Initial enthusiasm can fade without consistent leadership and programming. To address this, the organization should adopt a structured leadership model with defined roles and responsibilities. A successful structured leadership team follows other clubs', like President and Vice President, who oversee the student organization and the other roles, Planning Chair to plan the events/activities, Finance Chair to ensure the club stays in budget, Marketing Chair to raise my awareness about this club, and more. In conversations with student leaders involved in Local Church campus organizations at universities such as Boston University, Rutgers University, the University of Texas at Austin, and UCLA, I found that these groups have sustained participation for years through structured leadership teams and consistent weekly programming.⁷ Regular events and dedicated leadership will help maintain momentum.

⁶Birchman, Hannah. Personal interview. 2026.

⁷ Personal interviews with student leaders in Local Church campus organizations at Boston University, Rutgers University, University of Texas at Austin, and University of California, Los Angeles. 2026.

This proposal is not merely about one church or one group of students. It reflects a broader principle: access shapes participation. When institutions remove barriers, communities grow; otherwise, potential remains unrealized. By establishing an on-campus presence, the church can transform from a distant resource into an active part of student life. The path forward is clear. From sparking up the current active students like myself to finding an advisor, to registering as an on-campus organization, to utilizing current resources for initial meetings, to applying for funding from Student Union, each step is feasible and has been done before, either by other student groups that are a part of the Local Churches across the US as well as other religious groups on WashU campus, like Chabad. Each step contributes to WashU's larger goal of creating a more inclusive, accessible campus environment. The question is not whether this change is possible, but whether the students are willing to take the first step.

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